

Then there was the 1991 operation, dubbed “The Hawkeye Project” after the Hawkeye nickname for the state of Iowa; it was set up by brand manufacturers and the Rebate Information Center, along with investigators from the US Postal Service.

It all seemed harmless enough; families saving their empty boxes, can labels, and receipts and dropping them off at their local fundamentalist Christian school where volunteers would remove the proofs of purchase and attach them to refund forms to send in for cash refunds. “It was like a modern day quilting bee,” one resident was quoted as saying in the February 21, 1992, *Wall Street Journal*.

For years, this “Cash for Trash” program was enormously successful, raising an estimated five hundred thousand dollars over two decades. There was only one problem: it was illegal. It wasn’t the refunding itself that was illegal, but how it was done: by altering names and addresses for the checks to be mailed to. Most refunds limited the number of redemption offers a household could submit. To get around that clause, residents misspelled their name or changed their address slightly. When addresses of 982 claims were compared with the Postal Service’s verified list, 551 of them, or 56 percent, didn’t match.

What tipped off the authorities were the suspiciously high rebate rates in the town of Rock Valley, Iowa, with a population of 2540 residents, eleven churches, and the two private religious schools that residents supported with their trash. While the average response rate to a rebate offer from an Iowa zip code was perhaps 5 percent of all households, the town of Rock Valley had mind-boggling 62 percent response rate. At least one resident reported